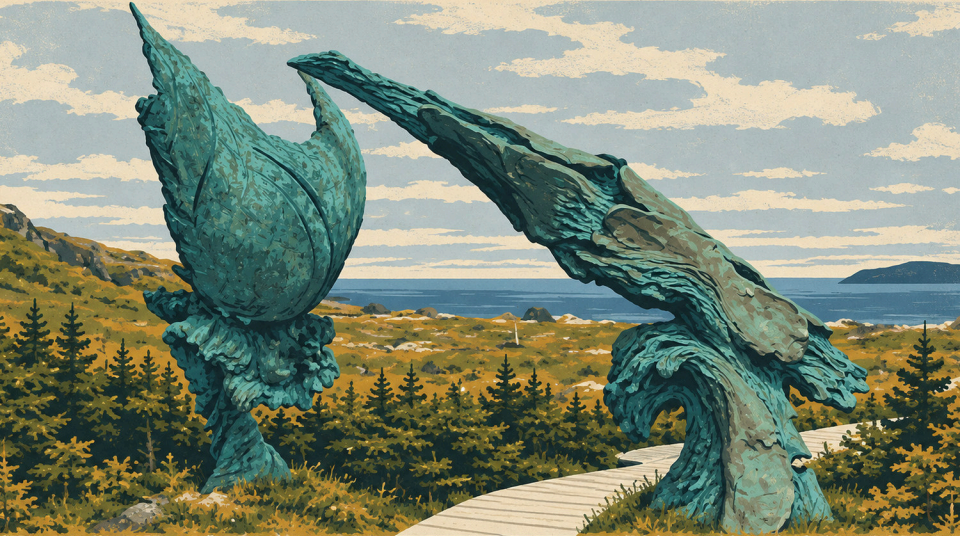




L'ANSE AUX MEADOWS

NEWFOUNDLAND AND LABRADOR

POST CARD

Hello, nephew!

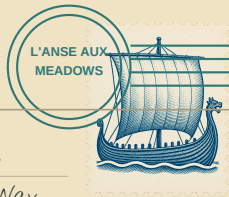
As you know, I've spent the last two years travelling and exploring our family history. I've discovered so many fascinating things - and perhaps even a small treasure!

Along with this postcard, you should have received the travel bag I carried everywhere during my journey.

I know how much you love mysteries and puzzles, so I've prepared an adventure for you. There's a surprise locked inside the bag. To open it, you'll need to follow my travels and solve the puzzles I've left behind.

This postcard comes from the first stop on my journey: L'Anse aux Meadows. It should help you get started.

With love,
Aunt Liv



TO

John Ericson

24 Longship Way

Ottawa ON K1L 1S1

Canada

FUN FACT

L'Anse aux Meadows turned up butternuts and worked butternut wood, though the nearest wild butternut trees grow hundreds of kilometres south, near the St. Lawrence. Read as evidence its people ranged well beyond it, into the wider "Vinland" the sagas describe.



BATTLE HARBOUR

NEWFOUNDLAND AND LABRADOR

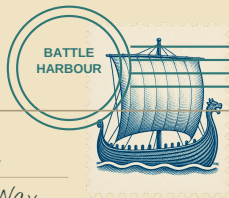
POST CARD

Markland today - 'Forest Land' in the old sagas, and they weren't exaggerating, it is gorgeous! Trees for miles, beautiful light and no one around!

It sounded like something with claws walked past the cabin last night - I didn't sleep a wink!

Still, you'd love it here.

Love,
Aunt Liv



TO

John Ericson

24 Longship Way

Ottawa ON K1L 1S1

Canada

FUN FACT

"Markland" appears in both the Saga of the Greenlanders and the Saga of Erik the Red as the second landfall on the Vinland voyages. Its "Forest Land" name likely marks the coast of Labrador, one of the few heavily wooded shores Norse sailors would have passed after leaving treeless Greenland.



BAFFIN ISLAND

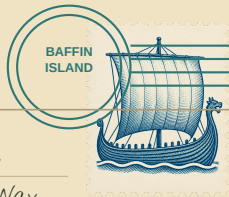
NUNAVUT

POST CARD

New stop: Helluland, "Flat Stone Land" to the sagas – and they weren't kidding about the stone either, not a tree in sight!

But last night the sky put on a show I'll never forget: green and purple curtains rippling right overhead. I stood out in the cold far too long just watching. Almost missed my supper!

Love,
Aunt Liv



TO

John Ericson

24 Longship Way

Ottawa ON K1L 1S1

Canada

FUN FACT

In the sagas, Helluland ("Flat-Stone Land") is generally identified with Baffin Island — its bare, rocky terrain matches medieval descriptions of a land with no grass, just glaciers and flat stones, in the Saga of Erik the Red and the Saga of the Greenlanders.



BRATTAHLÍÐ

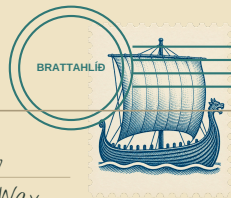
GREENLAND

POST CARD

Amazing place today! Brattahlíð,
Greenland where Leif actually grew up.
It's stunning here, green against the ice in
a way the name "Greenland" never
prepared me for. Erik apparently picked
that name on purpose, to lure settlers! I
really enjoy those small details!

Found the foundations of the little
church his wife had built, right on the
fjord.

With Love,
Aunt Liv



TO

John Ericson

24 Longship Way

Ottawa ON K1L 1S1

Canada

FUN FACT

Brattahlíð, Erik the Red's homestead near modern Qassiarsuk, seeded the Eastern Settlement -- the larger of Greenland's two medieval Norse colonies, home to thousands at its peak. Its ruins include Þjóðhildar's Church, a tiny turf chapel Erik built for his Christian wife around the year 1000.



CHÂLUS

HAUTE-VIENNE

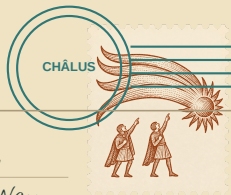
POST CARD

The one with the real paper trail, for once. Châlus, where Richard the Lionheart's whole story ends. He was besieging a tiny castle here over a supposed treasure hoard, of all things, when a crossbow bolt caught him in the shoulder.

The wound turned to gangrene and he was gone within the fortnight. Grim, but it's the kind of ending Rollo's whole line seems to build toward — the fighting, always the fighting. Found an old carving near the gate of a bolt just like the one that got him.

Odd place to start his family's story, at the very end of it.

With love,
Aunt Liv



TO

John Ericson

24 Longship Way

Ottawa ON K1L 1S1

Canada

FUN FACT

Richard the Lionheart — Rollo's own descendant, five generations down — died on 6 April 1199, twelve days after a crossbow bolt fired from the castle walls at Châlus-Chabrol struck his shoulder. The wound itself looked minor at first.



ROUEN

NORMANDY

POST CARD

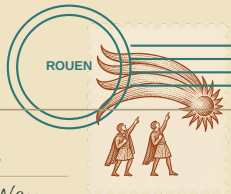
Today I got to visit Rouen, and it might be my favourite so far!

This was Rollo's own capital! The King gave Rollo all of Normandy so the fighting would stop.

Can't walk anywhere without counting my steps – always have. This afternoon was the city proper, the cathedral and the famous half-timbered houses. The city was vibrant today with lots of people milling about.

All that walking around made me crave fast-food: the battered poultry from Kentucky. Tonight's dinner was a bit fancier, the Inn I'm staying at is famous for their snails!

With love,
Aunt Liv



TO

John Ericson

24 Longship Way

Ottawa ON K1L 1S1

Canada

FUN FACT

Rouen Cathedral holds the actual heart of Richard the Lionheart, King of England and Duke of Normandy. Its spire also once held a record of its own: at 151 metres (495 feet) it's the tallest church spire in France, and was briefly the tallest structure in the world in the late 19th century.



BAYEUX

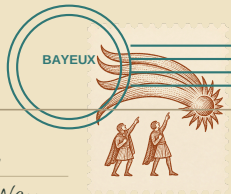
NORMANDY

POST CARD

Today was Bayeux and its famous Norman tapestry. The tapestry was awesome! It tells the story of William the Conqueror taking England in 1066 – and get this, he's one of Rollo's own descendants!

I'm obsessed with the style and the details, I spent hours looking at it. You know how much I like drawing (despite being terrible at it), so don't be surprised if you see a few drawings here and there.

Love,
Aunt Liv



TO

John Ericson

24 Longship Way

Ottawa ON K1L 1S1

Canada

FUN FACT

The Bayeux Tapestry shows Halley's Comet blazing over King Harold's court just before Hastings — the earliest known depiction of the comet, centuries before it got its name. A Victorian replica by the Leek Embroidery Society later added underpants to some of the tapestry's more, ah, undressed figures.



WINCHESTER

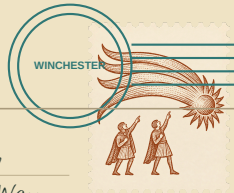
ENGLAND

POST CARD

Winchester today – freezing here, but worth every minute. This cathedral is where Richard the Lionheart was crowned a second time, in 1194, after finally being released from years held captive abroad.

Another one of Rollo's own line! Funny to think it all traces back to one deal, centuries earlier.

Love,
Aunt Liv



TO

John Ericson

24 Longship Way

Ottawa ON K1L 1S1

Canada

FUN FACT

The Round Table hanging in Winchester's Great Hall is a genuine medieval artifact — just not King Arthur's. Tree-ring dating shows it was built around 1290, and repainted for Henry VIII, who had his own face put on it as King Arthur.



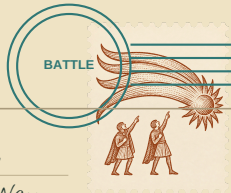
BATTLE

EAST SUSSEX

POST CARD

Today I visited Battle, the village where the Battle of Hastings happened. This is where William the Conqueror fought King Harold. William's victory sealed the conquest of England by the Normans. It's so cool to be able to see it in person, especially after spending hours looking at the tapestry!

Love,
Aunt Liv



TO

John Ericson

24 Longship Way

Ottawa ON K1L 1S1

Canada

FUN FACT

The Bayeux Tapestry's famous scene of Harold clutching an arrow in his eye may not be original — Victorian restorers reworked stitching in that exact spot, so historians still argue about how his death was actually shown.



ROUMARE FOREST

NORMANDY

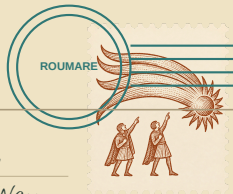
POST CARD

Rollo's own Normandy, and this little forest just outside Rouen has a local legend all its own, though nobody can really pin the story down.

What I can tell you is the wild boar are real: I counted a few slipping through the beech and oak, and for every one I actually saw, I'd bet good money there was a second one just out of sight.

I've ended up right back beside Rouen.

With love,
Aunt Liv



TO

John Ericson

24 Longship Way

Ottawa ON K1L 1S1

Canada

FUN FACT

This forest sits just outside Rouen, the city Rollo made his capital when he was granted all of Normandy in 911. Its own naming legend claims a link to him, though no source can confirm it — not every family story survives with its receipts.



WALCHEREN

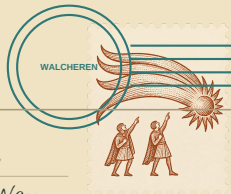
NETHERLANDS

POST CARD

Walcheren, in the Netherlands, where Vikings had already carved out their own toeholds on this coast – maybe even Rollo himself, if the old chronicles are to be believed.

Spent the evening watching the fishing boats come in with the tide and thought about him doing the exact same, centuries back.

With love,
Aunt Liv



TO

John Ericson

24 Longship Way

Ottawa ON K1L 1S1

Canada

FUN FACT

Some medieval accounts say Rollo spent years raiding and wintering around Frisia and Zeeland, this island included, before he ever became Duke of Normandy in 911. It's semi-legendary, but real Viking fleets were active on this exact coast in that same period.



DÖGURÐARNES

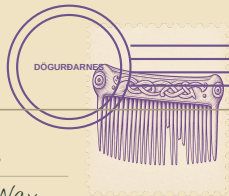
ICELAND

POST CARD

Dögurðarnes today.

What a beautiful place, I understand
why Aud stopped here during her journey.
I heard you can find some treasure
around here, especially historical coins
that fetch a pretty penny!

With love,
Aunt Liv



TO

John Ericson

24 Longship Way

Ottawa ON K1L 1S1

Canada

FUN FACT

Dögurðarnes takes its name from
dögurður, an Old Norse word for the day's
main meal — a rest stop preserved in the
map itself, long before it was a place
anyone lived.



HVAMMUR

ICELAND

POST CARD

Hvammur today.

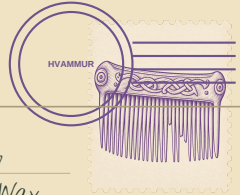
Such a lovely place and a great museum dedicated to Aud.

They even had a treasure hunt to find artifacts from Aud's time.

I was able to solve it and had a lovely time discovering the countryside. I particularly enjoyed the road that followed the forest.

I might just have to remember how many bridges, fords and gates I crossed.

With love,
Aunt Liv



TO

John Ericson

24 Longship Way

Ottawa ON K1L 1S1

Canada

FUN FACT

Aud claimed the entire valley between two rivers here in Dalasysla, then freed every thrall aboard her ships and granted each one land of their own. One, Vifill, got the valley still called Vifilsdalur today — she's one of very few women named as a primary land-claimant in Landnamabok, Iceland's own settlement record.



ESJUBERG

ICELAND

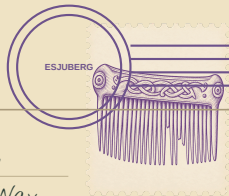
POST CARD

Esjuberg today.

Another beautiful place that Aud the Deep-Minded visited, my head is spinning with all the amazing landscapes!

Still amazed by the treasures I found!

With love,
Aunt Liv



TO

John Ericson

24 Longship Way

Ottawa ON K1L 1S1

Canada

FUN FACT

Esjuberg, on Kjalarnes, is where Laxdæla saga places Aud's meeting with her brother Helgi — and her refusal of his offer to settle down.



BJARNARHÖFN

ICELAND

POST CARD

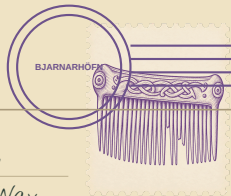
At her brother's harbor – the one Aud wintered in.

I've read everything I could find about her this trip, to the point that she feels like family (and she actually maybe was).

It was so awesome to find that comb alongside the coins, and the museum let me keep it!

This is actually the real treasure, a piece of history that we can use!

With love,
Aunt Liv



TO

John Ericson

24 Longship Way

Ottawa ON K1L 1S1

Canada

FUN FACT

Bjarnarhöfn means "Björn's harbor," named for Aud's own brother, whose land this was. She wintered here before pushing on to found Hvammur herself.



OSLO

NORWAY

POST CARD

I'm spending a whole week in Oslo, so much to do!

It's Harald's city – so much Viking history.

Found the quirkiest little museum near the harbour, all about hnefatafl, the chess-like old board game the Vikings loved and that we used to play with our own rules when you were younger.

Grabbed you a little souvenir from the gift shop so you can try – can you get the King to escape in exactly 3 moves? Count how far he travels each time.

Love,
Aunt Liv



TO

John Ericson

24 Longship Way

Ottawa ON K1L 1S1

Canada

FUN FACT

Snorri's saga credits Harald with founding Oslo around 1050 — but a church and cemetery already stood there by the year 1000, and in 2026 archaeologists found a Viking boat grave buried beneath the site of his own royal manor, older than his reign.



STARAYA LADOGA

RUSSIA

POST CARD

Days here move slower than I expected,
and I love it.

Rurik supposedly ruled from right here, if
the old chronicles are true.

I climbed up on the fortress wall for a
look at the whole river bend.

Nobody warned me how far this feels
from anywhere else.

Keeping my postcards dry has become a
full-time job in this weather.

Love,
Aunt Liv



STARAYA
LADOGA



TO

John Ericson

24 Longship Way

Ottawa ON K1L 1S1

Canada

FUN FACT

A wooden stick found at Staraya Ladoga in 1950 carries 52 Younger Futhark runes — likely a fragment of skaldic verse, dated to around 840–865 AD, one of the oldest runic inscriptions ever found in Russia. It's still on display in the Hermitage.



KYIV
UKRAINE

POST CARD

Kyiv, and it might be the most beautiful city on this whole trip – golden domes catching the light on every hill.

Stopped by St. Michael's this morning and lit a candle for you. Cheesy, I know. Here's a little riddle for you, the Kind we used to trade back and forth: I'm sweet, but no fruit tree grew me. I'm gold, but no smith ever cast me. Thousands of tiny workers made me and set six-sided walls to guard me.

Love,
Aunt Liv



TO

John Ericson

24 Longship Way

Ottawa ON K1L 1S1

Canada

FUN FACT

Oleg of Novgorod made Kyiv the Rus' capital and, per the Primary Chronicle, sailed on Constantinople in 907 — supposedly nailing his shield to the gates (a legend modern historians doubt). The real treaty that followed in 911 gave Rus' merchants tax-free trading rights there for up to six months.



HEDEBY

GERMANY

POST CARD

Today: Hedeby – barely a Hedeby left to stand in, just a green ring of earthworks where the ramparts ran. From here I'm turning south: nothing but Mediterranean weather for the rest of this trip.

A woodcarver at the reconstruction huts showed me how the old branch-runes worked – count the branches one way for the family, the other way for the letter. I copied his Key out for you before I forgot it.

Love,
Aunt Liv

his Key, copied out:

1 – f u þ ö r k

2 – h n i a s

3 – t b m l r'

(left branches = which row. right = where in it.)



TO

John Ericson

24 Longship Way

Ottawa ON K1L 1S1

Canada

FUN FACT

In 1050, during his war with Denmark, Harald burned Hedeby to the ground — sailing burning ships straight into the harbour. Archaeologists later found their charred timbers still lying in the Schlei.



SICILY

ITALY

POST CARD

Aci Castello today.

A Norman Castle in Sicily! It's crazy to think how far they travelled!

Being a good tourist, I enjoyed a gelato while walking around the ruins. Little did I know, that is a great way to attract wildlife. A raven followed me the whole time!

Half convinced it was you, checking up on me.

Love,
Aunt Liv



TO

John Ericson

24 Longship Way

Ottawa ON K1L 1S1

Canada

FUN FACT

Aci Castello's rock is over 500,000 years old — lava that cooled underwater into a mass of glassy basalt pillars. The castle itself later spent three centuries as a prison, until an 1818 earthquake made it too unsafe to hold anyone.



PATARA

TURKEY

POST CARD

Patara is the last stop of my travels
for now.

I had so much fun exploring the Vikings
and Norse travels!

For your university summer break, I
would love for you to join me on my next
adventure. You have one more puzzle to
solve and you will get your rewards!

With love,
Aunt Liv



TO

John Ericson

24 Longship Way

Ottawa ON K1L 1S1

Canada

FUN FACT

Archaeologists actually found a real
9th/10th-century Viking sword in 2018 in
Patara. It almost certainly belonged to a
Varangian Guard soldier. Harald
Hardrada, later King of Norway, was a
prominent member of the Varangian
Guard.



CONSTANTINOPLE

TURKEY

POST CARD

Constantinople – well, Istanbul now, but I like the old name for this trip.

Impossible not to think about Harald everywhere here, this is where he made his fortune, long before Norway ever heard of him.

Found this in a little shop near the Hippodrome, couldn't resist.



Love,
Aunt Liv



TO

John Ericson

24 Longship Way

Ottawa ON K1L 1S1

Canada

FUN FACT

Harald really did serve here — in the Byzantine emperor's own Varangian Guard, from 1034 to 1043, under three different emperors. The wealth he brought home from Constantinople is what funded his eventual claim to the throne of Norway.